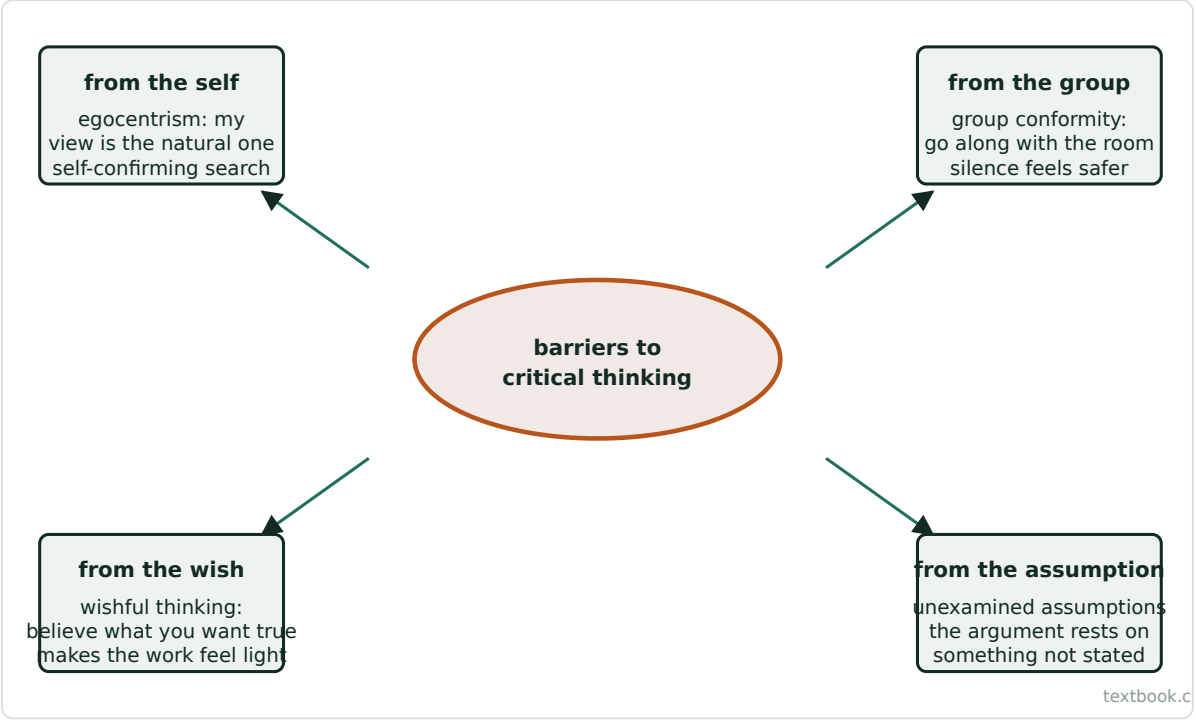
Draft - expert review pending

Note: This unit is complete and passes the platform's automated checks, but it is not reviewed yet. So, treat its sources and claims with care. You are encouraged to report errors and provide feedback.

Topic 1.3 - What gets in the way

A real classroom situation

A head teacher in a Karachi primary school decides to keep the same timetable he has used for twelve years because, he says, "we have always done it this way and our results have been fine." When a younger teacher suggests trialling a different afternoon order so that the hardest subject is not last, the head dismisses the idea without examining it. He is not being stubborn on purpose. He is caught in one of the most common barriers to critical thinking, and he cannot see it from the inside.



Barrier	A sentence that reveals it	One question that interrupts it
egocentrism	"I was taught this way and I turned out fine, so it is sound"	"Would it convince a teacher whose results are different?"
self-confirming search	"I only notice the pupils who prove my point"	"What would a pupil who disagrees look like?"
group conformity	"I stayed silent because everyone else agreed"	"What would you say if no one else had spoken yet?"
wishful thinking	"If I set less homework, results will stay the same"	"What evidence would make you change your mind?"
unexamined assumption	"These pupils cannot manage group work"	"What are you assuming about their preparation?"
sociocentrism	"We have always done it this way in this school"	"What reason would hold even if no one had done it before?"

textbook.com.pk

textbook.com.pk

This topic names the barriers that stop people - including experienced teachers - from reasoning well, so that you can spot them in your own thinking and in staffroom discussion.

Explanation

Barriers to critical thinking

Critical thinking is not stopped by a lack of intelligence. It is stopped by habits of mind that feel reasonable from the inside but distort judgement. Bassham et al. (2010) group them by where they come from.

From the self. Egocentrism is the habit of seeing everything from your own position and assuming your view is the natural one. In a staffroom it sounds like, "I was taught this way and I turned out fine, so there is nothing wrong with it." A related barrier is *self-confirming search*: noticing every fact that supports what you already believe and ignoring the rest. A teacher

who is sure a pupil is "lazy" will notice every missed assignment and overlook the weeks the pupil tried hard.

From the group. Group conformity is the pressure to think along with those around you. In a school it is often stronger than people admit: a teacher who privately doubts a new policy will stay silent when everyone else nods, because disagreeing feels disloyal or risky. The barrier is not that the group is always wrong; it is that the group's view is accepted without being examined.

From the wish. Wishful thinking is believing a claim because you want it to be true. "If I set less homework, my pupils will learn just as well" may be right, but if the reason for believing it is that marking is tiring, the wish is doing the work, not the evidence.

From the assumption. Every piece of reasoning rests on assumptions the speaker does not state. Often they are harmless. But sometimes an unexamined assumption carries the whole argument: "These practise-school pupils cannot manage group work" rests on an assumption about what they have been prepared for, and if that assumption is wrong, the conclusion falls with it.

Why the barriers matter for teachers

None of these barriers is a character flaw. Egocentrism and group conformity are ordinary cognitive defaults - the mind's way of saving effort. That is precisely why they are dangerous: they feel normal. Empirical work with university students confirms the picture: making learners aware of confirmation bias, social pressure to conform, framing and poor risk assessment - the same family of barriers this topic names - measurably grows their critical dispositions (Aston, 2024). A teacher who treats them as personal faults in others ("he is stubborn", "she just follows the crowd") will stop listening. A teacher who treats them as habits to watch for - in herself as much as in others - is thinking more critically already.

Common misconception. "Critical thinking means criticising" and "a claim and an argument are the same thing" are not the only barriers trainees bring. Two others sit inside this topic: the idea that "being intelligent and thinking critically are the same" (intelligence can defend a bad belief cleverly) and the idea that critical thinking is a personality you have or lack. Naming the barriers as ordinary habits, not character flaws, is what makes them something you can work on.

Activity: Name the barrier

Work in pairs. About 15 minutes.

Read each short classroom reasoning below and decide which barrier it most shows: egocentrism, group conformity, wishful thinking, or an unexampled assumption. Write one sentence explaining your choice and one question that would interrupt the reasoning.

1. "We should not change the exam format; the parents expect the old one."
2. "My pupils will do fine in the board exam because I have covered every topic."
3. "Streaming by ability cannot be unfair - every school does it."
4. "This pupil failed because she did not revise."

Compare your answers with another pair. Where you chose different barriers, explain your reasoning.

Check your understanding

1. **Remember** Name the four sources from which barriers to critical thinking come.

2. **Understand** Explain why group conformity is a cognitive default rather than a character flaw, in one or two sentences.

3. **Apply** A teacher says, "I know my method works because my results are always good." Which barrier does that reasoning most show, and why?

Summary

The barriers to critical thinking come from the self, the group, the wish and unexamined assumptions. They are ordinary habits of mind, not character flaws, which is what makes them hard to spot and worth watching for - especially in your own reasoning.

Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

- [ ] I can name the four sources of barriers and give an example of each.
- [ ] I can recognise which barrier a described piece of teacher reasoning shows.
- [ ] I can explain why treating barriers as habits rather than flaws matters in a staffroom.

Try this at your practicum school

Recall one recent staffroom or classroom decision you were part of. Write down the reasoning that was offered and then write one sentence naming the barrier it most showed. Be honest with yourself

- the point is to practise spotting the habit, not to judge the people involved.

Summative task

Take this reasoning: **"We cannot try peer assessment in grade 4; the parents will think we are not doing our job."** Write a short paragraph (80-120 words) naming the barrier it most shows, explaining why, and offering one question that would interrupt the reasoning.

Mini-rubric

Criterion	Levels
Barrier identified	0-2: names the barrier correctly and from the right source / names a barrier but misreads the source / none.
Explanation	0-3: specific reasoning linking the text to the barrier / vague or generic / none. (**Analyze**: cites a specific piece of the reasoning as evidence.)
Clarity	0-2: paragraph coherent and within word band / unclear or over length.

Further reading

Bassham, G., Irwin, W., Nardone, H., & Wallace, J. M. (2010). *Critical thinking: A student's introduction* (4th ed.). McGraw-Hill. Chapter 4-5 examines the barriers to critical thinking drawn on in this topic.

Aston, K. J. (2024). "Why is this hard, to have critical thinking?" Exploring the factors affecting critical thinking with international higher education students. *Active Learning in Higher Education*, 25(3), 537-550. https://doi.org/10.1177/14697874231168341. Shows that awareness of barriers such as confirmation bias and social pressure grows learners' critical dispositions.

Was this page helpful? Yes

Tip: select any text on this page first to comment on that specific passage - or leave nothing selected for general feedback.

Give feedback